One could argue that Gandhi got more comments because he was often abused more by the Twitterati, but the fact that he was getting more retweets and likes per tweet is still revealing. It shows that he was building an alternative online audience to Modi's. It was smaller for sure—about one-fifth the size of the prime minister's—but it was there. This was crucial progress, given that the Congress party was playing catch-up, having given the BJP a free run on social media for a long time.

We found the same patterns when we analysed Twitter data using Facebook's CrowdTangle tool: Gandhi's growth rate was faster on Twitter (349 per cent) than Modi's (57 per cent, albeit from a much larger base) from mid-2017 to 2019 and the interaction rate for his posts (0.45) was higher than Modi's (0.05%). Again, Modi remained way ahead on size (see Figures 7.5 and 7.6), but Gandhi was holding his own.

Figure 7.4: Rahul Gandhi vs Narendra Modi on Twitter (2017–2019)

